

Microsoft Publisher

For Schools | Businesses | NGOs | Government Offices

Introduction to Microsoft Publisher

Microsoft Publisher is a desktop publishing application from Microsoft Office. Unlike Word, which focuses on text, Publisher focuses on visual design and page layout. It helps you create professional-looking documents quickly and easily.

Publisher is used to create:

- Flyers, posters and banners
- Brochures and catalogues
- Newsletters and magazines
- Business cards and greeting cards
- Certificates and awards
- Menus, programmes and reports

Why Learn Publisher?
Easy to use — no design experience needed
Built-in templates save time
Professional output for print and digital use
Works with other Microsoft Office apps
Widely used in schools, offices, NGOs and government

LEVEL 1 — BEGINNER

Learning Objectives — Beginner Level

1. Understand the Publisher workspace and tools
2. Create a new publication from scratch or a template
3. Add, format and arrange text in text boxes
4. Insert and adjust images and basic shapes
5. Save and print a simple publication

1.1 The Publisher Interface

When you open Publisher, you see the main workspace. Understanding each part helps you work faster.

Interface Element	What It Does
Ribbon	The toolbar at the top with all commands grouped by tabs (Home, Insert, Page Design, etc.)
Publication Page	The white area in the centre — this is your design canvas
Scratch Area	The grey area around the canvas — you can place objects here temporarily
Page Navigation	Panel on the left showing thumbnails of all pages
Task Panes	Panels that appear on the right with extra options (e.g. templates, formatting)
Rulers	Horizontal and vertical rulers help you measure and align objects precisely
Zoom Controls	Bottom-right slider — zoom in to see detail or zoom out to see the full page
Status Bar	Bottom strip showing page number, zoom level and object position

Key Ribbon Tabs

- Home – Text formatting (font, size, bold, colour, alignment)
- Insert – Add text boxes, images, shapes, tables, headers and page numbers
- Page Design – Change page size, orientation, colour schemes and font schemes
- Mailings – Mail merge for personalised documents
- Review – Spelling check and design checker
- View – Change how you see the page (zoom, guides, rulers)

1.2 Creating Publications

You can start a publication in two ways: from scratch (blank page) or using a built-in template.

Starting a Blank Publication

1. Open Publisher and click Blank
2. Choose a page size (A4, A5, Letter, etc.)
3. Click Create
4. Your blank canvas is ready

Common Page Sizes

Page Size	Use
A4	210 x 297 mm — standard office paper (most countries)
A5	148 x 210 mm — half of A4, good for leaflets
Letter	8.5 x 11 in — standard in USA
Custom	Set any width and height you need

Saving Your Publication

- Ctrl + S — Save
- Save as .pub format to keep Publisher features
- Save as PDF for sharing with people who do not have Publisher
- File > Export > Save for Photo Printing for high-quality images

Tip: Auto-Save

Turn on Auto-Save in File > Options > Save.

Set it to save every 5–10 minutes so you never lose your work.

1.3 Using Templates

Templates are ready-made designs. You only need to change the text and images. They save a lot of time.

Finding Templates

5. Open Publisher
6. In the search box, type what you need (e.g. 'flyer', 'newsletter', 'business card')
7. Click a template to preview it
8. Click Create to open it

Customising a Template

- Click any text to select it, then type your own content
- Click any image and press Delete, then insert your own

- Change colours using Page Design > Colour Schemes
- Change fonts using Page Design > Font Schemes
- Add or remove pages as needed

Template Type	Best For
Business Card	Contact details for professionals
Newsletter	Monthly update for a school, church or organisation
Brochure	Product or service information in a folded design
Flyer	Announcement for an event or promotion
Certificate	Award or completion certificate
Calendar	Monthly or yearly calendar with custom photos

1.4 Text Formatting

In Publisher, all text lives inside text boxes. You must insert a text box before you can type.

Inserting a Text Box

9. Click Insert tab
10. Click Draw Text Box
11. Click and drag on the page to draw the box
12. Type your text inside

Formatting Text

Formatting Tool	What It Does
Font	Change the style of letters (Arial, Times New Roman, etc.)
Font Size	Make text bigger or smaller (measured in points — 12pt is normal body text)
Bold	Ctrl + B — makes text thick and strong
Italic	Ctrl + I — slants text for emphasis
Underline	Ctrl + U — adds a line under text
Font Colour	Change the colour of text using the A with colour bar
Alignment	Left, Centre, Right, or Justified — controls how text sits in the box
Line Spacing	Controls the space between lines of text
Text Effects	Shadow, outline, glow — used for titles and headings

Linking Text Boxes

If your text is too long for one box, you can link text boxes so the text flows from one box to another automatically.

13. Click the first text box
14. Go to Text Box Tools > Format tab
15. Click Create Link
16. Click the second text box — text will flow into it

Design Tip: Fonts

Use no more than 2 fonts in one document.

Example: Use a bold font for headings (e.g. Impact) and a clean font for body text (e.g. Arial).

Avoid decorative fonts for long paragraphs — they are hard to read.

1.5 Images and Shapes

Inserting Images

17. Click Insert > Pictures
18. Choose 'This Device' to use a photo from your computer
19. Or choose 'Online Pictures' to search the internet
20. Click the image and click Insert

Working with Images

Action	How to Do It
Resize	Click the image, then drag the corner handles — hold Shift to keep proportions
Move	Click and drag the image to a new position
Crop	Picture Tools > Crop — cut away unwanted parts of an image
Wrap Text	Controls how text flows around the image (inline, square, tight, behind text)
Border	Add a frame/border around an image using Picture Tools > Border
Effects	Add shadows, reflections and soft edges using Picture Tools > Picture Effects

Inserting Shapes

- Click Insert > Shapes
- Choose a shape (rectangle, circle, arrow, star, etc.)
- Click and drag to draw it on the page
- Use Drawing Tools > Format to change fill colour, border colour and effects

Ordering and Grouping Objects

Action	What It Does
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Bring to Front	Move an object above all others
Send to Back	Move an object behind all others
Bring Forward	Move an object one layer up
Send Backward	Move an object one layer down
Group	Select multiple objects, right-click > Group — move and resize them as one
Ungroup	Right-click a group > Ungroup — edit individual objects again
Align	Home > Arrange > Align — line up objects neatly on the page

Mini Project — BEGINNER: Personal Name Card

Goal: Design a simple personal name card (business card size)

Steps:

1. Open Publisher and choose Business Card template
2. Replace the name with your own full name
3. Add your phone number, email address and a title (e.g. Student, Teacher)
4. Change the colour scheme to one you like
5. Insert a small shape or icon as a logo
6. Save the file as a PDF and print it

Skills Practised: Templates, text formatting, images, shapes, saving

LEVEL 2 — INTERMEDIATE

Learning Objectives — Intermediate Level

1. Design professional flyers, brochures and newsletters
2. Use advanced page layout tools (columns, guides, master pages)
3. Apply design principles for attractive publications
4. Use Publisher's design tools (colour schemes, building blocks, borders)
5. Prepare publications for professional printing

2.1 Flyers

A flyer is a single-page document designed to attract attention quickly. It is used to announce events, promotions, services or information.

Key Elements of a Good Flyer

Element	Purpose
Headline	Large, bold text that grabs attention immediately
Sub-headline	A shorter line that explains the headline
Body Text	Key details: what, where, when, how much, contact
Call to Action	What you want the reader to do (Call Now, Visit Us, Register Here)
Image	A strong photo or graphic that supports the message
Contact Info	Phone, email, website, social media handles
Logo	Organisation or business logo for credibility

Designing a Flyer in Publisher

21. Open a Flyer template or blank A4 page
22. Set a strong background colour or image
23. Insert a large text box at the top for the headline
24. Add supporting text boxes for details
25. Insert a relevant image and crop it neatly
26. Add your logo and contact information at the bottom
27. Use Page Design > Colour Schemes to match your brand
28. Check alignment using View > Guides and Ruler Guides

Flyer Design Tips

- Keep it simple — one main message only
- Use high contrast (dark text on light background or vice versa)
- Leave white space — do not fill every corner

- Use maximum 3 colours for a clean look
- Make the call to action the most visible element after the headline

2.2 Brochures

A brochure is a folded document that provides detailed information about a product, service or organisation. The most common type is the tri-fold (three panels).

Understanding Brochure Panels

Panel	What Goes Here
Front Cover	Headline, image, organisation name — must attract the reader
Back Panel	Contact details, map, social media, QR code, logo
Inside Panels	Detailed content: services, products, benefits, schedule
Spine	Narrow middle section (tri-fold) — good for a tagline

Creating a Tri-Fold Brochure

29. Go to File > New, search for 'Brochure'
30. Choose a tri-fold template
31. Publisher automatically sets up 3 panels per side
32. Fill in the front cover first — it must be eye-catching
33. Add detailed content to inside panels
34. Place contact info and map on the back panel
35. Go to File > Print Preview to check how it will look when folded

Printing Tip: Brochures

Set your printer to print on BOTH SIDES of paper.

Choose 'Flip on short edge' for portrait brochures.

Do a test print on plain paper before using glossy paper.

2.3 Newsletters

A newsletter is a regular publication sent to an audience to share news, updates and information. Publisher makes it easy to create professional multi-page newsletters.

Newsletter Structure

Section	Description
Masthead	Top section with newsletter name, date, volume/issue number and logo
Lead Story	Most important article — placed top-left with a strong headline

Supporting Stories	Smaller articles in columns below the lead story
Sidebar	Short items on the side: quick facts, quotes, tips, upcoming events
Images	Photos and graphics to break up text and add visual interest
Footer	Organisation name, address, unsubscribe info, page number

Setting Up a Newsletter Layout

36. Choose a newsletter template or start with a blank multi-page document
37. Go to Insert > Header and add the newsletter name at the top
38. Insert > Footer and add page number: Insert > Page Number
39. Use Insert > Draw Text Box to create columns for articles
40. For automatic columns, select a text box, go to Text Box Tools > Format > Columns
41. Set number of columns (usually 2 or 3 for newsletters)
42. Add a masthead using a large text box with coloured background
43. Link text boxes for articles that continue across pages

2.4 Page Layouts

Good page layout makes your publication easy to read and professional. Publisher provides several tools for this.

Master Pages

A Master Page is like a background template applied to all pages. Anything on the Master Page appears on every page automatically.

44. Go to View > Master Page
45. Add elements that should appear on every page (logo, page borders, background colours, footers)
46. Click Close Master Page when done
47. All pages will now show those elements automatically

Guides and Alignment

Layout Tool	How It Helps
Ruler Guides	Drag from the ruler to create blue guide lines — helps you align objects
Grid Guides	Page Design > Guides — adds a grid across the page
Margin Guides	Shows the safe printing area (usually shown in blue)
Snap to Guides	Objects automatically snap to guide lines when moved near them
Align Objects	Select multiple objects, use Home > Arrange > Align to line them up

Working with Columns

- Select a text box, go to Text Box Tools > Format > Columns

- Choose 2, 3 or more columns
- Publisher divides the text box evenly
- Use for newsletters, catalogues and magazines

Adding Pages

- Right-click a page thumbnail in the left panel
- Choose Insert Page
- Choose whether to copy the layout from an existing page

2.5 Design Tools

Colour Schemes

A colour scheme is a set of coordinated colours applied across your publication. Changing one scheme instantly updates all colours.

48. Go to Page Design > Colour Schemes
49. Click any scheme to preview it
50. Click to apply — all text boxes, shapes and borders update automatically
51. To create a custom scheme, click Create New Colour Scheme

Font Schemes

A font scheme pairs a heading font with a body font. This ensures consistent, professional typography throughout.

52. Go to Page Design > Font Schemes
53. Choose a pairing (e.g. Heading: Verdana, Body: Georgia)
54. Click to apply across all text in the publication

Building Blocks

Building Blocks are pre-designed elements you can insert and customise. They include page parts, borders, advertisements, calendars and attention getters.

55. Go to Insert > Building Blocks
56. Browse categories: Page Parts, Borders and Accents, Advertisements, Calendars, Headlines
57. Click an item to insert it onto your page
58. Resize and customise as needed

Background

- Page Design > Background — add colour gradients or patterns behind your page
- Use light backgrounds for documents with lots of text
- Strong backgrounds work well for flyers and posters

Design Checker

Before printing or sending, run the Design Checker to find problems.

59. Go to File > Info > Design Checker
60. Click Run Design Checker
61. It will flag issues like: objects off the page, empty text boxes, images with low resolution, text overflow
62. Fix each issue before sending to the printer

Mini Project — INTERMEDIATE: Event Flyer
Goal: Design a promotional flyer for a community or school event
Steps:
1. Open a blank A4 page in Portrait orientation
2. Create a coloured header strip with the event name in large bold text
3. Add event details: Date, Time, Venue, Activities, Cost (if any)
4. Insert a relevant image (school hall, sport event, concert, etc.)
5. Add a 'Call to Action' box (e.g. Register by Friday / Call 0700 000 000)
6. Apply a matching colour scheme and font scheme
7. Insert a shape as a decorative element
8. Run Design Checker and fix any issues
9. Export as PDF for sharing on WhatsApp or printing
Skills Practised: Flyers, layout, design tools, colour schemes, export

Real-World Uses of Microsoft Publisher

Publisher is used every day by real organisations around the world. Here are examples from four sectors.

Schools and Educational Institutions

Publication Type	Use in Schools
Event Flyers	Announce sports day, open day, prize-giving, parent meetings
School Newsletter	Weekly or monthly update for parents and guardians
Certificates	Print certificates for best student, attendance, competitions
Notice Board Posters	Rules, timetables, motivational posters for classrooms
Student Magazines	Student journalism projects and school publications
Permission Slips	Formatted forms for trips and activities
Report Cards	Formatted termly or annual student reports
Timetables	Class schedules formatted in tables with colour coding

Businesses and Companies

Publication Type	Use in Business
Business Cards	Professional cards with company branding
Product Catalogues	Showcase products with images and prices
Promotional Flyers	Announce sales, new products, special offers
Company Newsletters	Internal staff communications and external client updates
Brochures	Service overview for new clients
Menus	Restaurant and café menus with photos
Invoices and Receipts	Professional billing documents with company logo
Annual Reports	Summary of company performance for stakeholders

NGOs and Non-Profit Organisations

Publication Type	Use in NGOs
Awareness Posters	Health campaigns, environment, human rights
Fundraising Flyers	Announce charity events, donation drives
Donor Reports	Update donors on how funds were used
Volunteer Handbooks	Guide new volunteers on roles and procedures

Programme Brochures	Explain services and programmes to beneficiaries
Impact Reports	Showcase results and success stories
Training Materials	Handouts and guides for community training sessions
Community Calendars	Events and health services schedule

Government Offices and Public Services

Publication Type	Use in Government
Public Notices	Official announcements to citizens
Policy Summaries	Simplified explanations of laws and policies
Tax and Licence Forms	Formatted application and declaration forms
Health Advisories	Public health messages and guidelines
Event Programmes	National day programmes and ceremony booklets
Departmental Reports	Quarterly and annual performance reports
Staff Newsletters	Internal communication within departments
Training Certificates	Completion certificates for civil servant training

Essential Keyboard Shortcuts

Learning shortcuts saves time and makes you faster. Practice these every day until they become automatic.

File and Navigation Shortcuts

Shortcut	Action	Shortcut	Action
Shortcut	Action	Shortcut	Action
Ctrl + N	New publication	Ctrl + O	Open file
Ctrl + S	Save	Ctrl + P	Print
Ctrl + Z	Undo	Ctrl + Y	Redo
Ctrl + W	Close publication	F7	Spell check
Ctrl + F	Find text	Ctrl + H	Find and Replace
Ctrl + Home	Go to first page	Ctrl + End	Go to last page
F5	Go to page	Esc	Deselect / cancel

Text Formatting Shortcuts

Shortcut	Action	Shortcut	Action
Shortcut	Action	Shortcut	Action
Ctrl + B	Bold	Ctrl + I	Italic
Ctrl + U	Underline	Ctrl + E	Centre align
Ctrl + L	Left align	Ctrl + R	Right align
Ctrl + J	Justify	Ctrl + A	Select all
Ctrl + C	Copy	Ctrl + V	Paste
Ctrl + X	Cut	Ctrl + D	Duplicate object
Shift+F3	Change case	Ctrl+Space	Clear formatting

Object and Layout Shortcuts

Shortcut	Action	Shortcut	Action
Shortcut	Action	Shortcut	Action
Ctrl + G	Group objects	Ctrl + Shift + G	Ungroup
Ctrl + Shift + F	Bring to front	Ctrl + Shift + B	Send to back
Ctrl + M	Insert text box	Ctrl + Shift + M	Insert picture
F2	Edit text in box	Tab	Select next object
Arrow keys	Nudge object	Ctrl + arrows	Nudge by small amount
Ctrl + Shift + A	Align objects	Ctrl + 1	Zoom 100%
Ctrl + Shift + H	Flip horizontal	Ctrl + Shift + V	Flip vertical

Best Practices

Follow these guidelines to produce professional, effective publications every time.

1. Plan Before You Design

- Decide on your purpose: What is this publication for?
- Know your audience: Who will read it?
- Gather all content first: text, images, logos, contact details
- Sketch a rough layout on paper before opening Publisher

2. Use Consistent Design

- Stick to one colour scheme throughout the document
- Use only 2–3 fonts maximum
- Keep margins and spacing consistent on all pages
- Use the same style for all headings, all body text and all captions

3. Keep It Simple

- One main message per publication
- Do not crowd the page — use white space (empty space) intentionally
- Shorter text is almost always better
- One or two strong images beat many small ones

4. Use High-Quality Images

- Use images at least 300 DPI (dots per inch) for print
- Low-resolution images (from WhatsApp or small websites) look blurry when printed
- Check image resolution: right-click image in Publisher > Format Picture > Size
- Use PNG files for logos (they have transparent backgrounds)

5. Always Check Before Printing

- Run Design Checker: File > Info > Design Checker
- Check spelling: Review > Spelling (F7)
- Preview: File > Print Preview — check every page
- Check that no text is cut off or hidden behind images
- Do a test print on plain paper before using expensive paper

6. Save Properly

- Save as .pub for future editing
- Export as PDF before printing or sharing — this preserves all fonts and layout
- Keep a backup copy on a USB drive or cloud storage

7. Prepare Correctly for Printing

Setting	Recommended Value
Setting	Recommended Value
Resolution	300 DPI for professional print; 150 DPI for home print
Bleed	Add 3mm bleed if printing to the edge of the paper
Colour Mode	CMYK for professional printing; RGB is fine for home printing
Embed Fonts	File > Pack and Go > Take to a Commercial Printing Service
File Format	PDF (PDF/X-1a or PDF/X-3 for professional printers)

Common Mistakes to Avoid

These are the most frequent errors made by beginners and how to fix them.

Common Mistake	How to Avoid It
Too many fonts	Use a maximum of 2–3 fonts. More fonts make the document look messy and unprofessional.
Too many colours	Limit to 3 colours. Use a Publisher colour scheme to keep it balanced.
Crowded layout	Leave breathing space (white space). Do not fill every corner of the page.
Low-resolution images	Always use high-quality images. Blurry images make the whole document look poor.
Text too small	Body text should be at least 10–12pt. Headings should be 16–24pt or larger.
Ignoring alignment	Use guides and the Align tool. Misaligned objects look accidental and sloppy.
Saving only as .pub	Always export a PDF copy. If someone opens your .pub on a different computer, fonts may not display correctly.
Forgetting spell check	Always run spell check before printing. Spelling errors destroy credibility.
Skipping Design Checker	Run Design Checker before printing. It catches hidden problems automatically.
Text box overflow	If a text box has a red overflow indicator, some text is hidden. Resize the box or reduce the text.
Wrong page size	Check Page Design > Page Setup matches your actual paper size before printing.
Using too many effects	Shadows, gradients and glows are useful in small amounts. Too many effects look amateur.
Not grouping objects	Group related objects so they move together. Ungrouped objects get accidentally moved.
Printing without preview	Always use File > Print Preview before sending to the printer.
No contact information	For any public-facing document, always include at least one way to contact the organisation.

Final Project

Design a Complete 2-Page Newsletter

Project Overview

You will design a 2-page newsletter for a real or imaginary organisation.

This project brings together all the skills from both levels of this guide.

You will be assessed on design quality, correct use of Publisher tools and professionalism.

Project Requirements

Page 1 — Front Page

- 63. A masthead with the newsletter name, date, volume/issue number and organisation logo
- 64. One lead story with a headline (minimum 16pt, bold), body text and one image
- 65. One sidebar with a short item (quote, tip or quick fact)
- 66. A footer with the organisation name and page number

Page 2 — Inside Page

- 67. Two or three articles in a 2 or 3 column layout
- 68. At least one image per article
- 69. A 'Upcoming Events' box or table
- 70. A contact information section at the bottom

Design Requirements

- Use one consistent colour scheme throughout both pages
- Use a Master Page for the footer (page number and organisation name)
- Use maximum 2 fonts — one for headings, one for body text
- All objects must be properly aligned — use guides
- No text overflow on any text box

Technical Requirements

Requirement	Specification
Page Size	A4 (210 x 297 mm)
Orientation	Portrait
Margins	15mm on all sides
Minimum Pages	2 pages
Images	At least 3 images (high resolution)
Colour Scheme	Must use a Publisher colour scheme

Font Scheme	Must use a Publisher font scheme or clearly defined custom fonts
Export Format	Final file submitted as PDF

Choose Your Newsletter Theme

- School newsletter for parents and students
- Business newsletter for customers or staff
- NGO newsletter for donors and community members
- Government department update for citizens
- Sports club or church newsletter